magnitude was the Vande Bharat Mission, perhaps the largest such in history, through which its citizens abroad came home during Covid. There were many others, ranging from the Yemen conflict and Nepal earthquake to the South Sudan violence and Kabul's capture.

Together, they signify not only a more frequent activity in comparison to India's own past but also when assessed against the proclivity of other states. The generous usage of funds abroad to mitigate distress situations affirms this mindset. India matters because it is not only pulling its own weight abroad more but extending a helping hand to others while doing so.

EXPANDING STRATEGIC HORIZONS

International relations understandably assign a great importance to geography. The Indian peninsula has a visible centrality to the ocean that is named after it. That this sea space is also a particularly active arena of maritime projection makes it even more significant. There is a continental dimension to India's presence as well. Without its active participation, no trans-Asia connectivity initiative can really take off. After all, it provides the contiguous link between Southeast Asia and the Gulf. Location confers a centrality to India, quite apart from the potential global power that has risen just before it. Management of their overlapping peripheries becomes an onerous responsibility. That many of India's other immediate neighbours also share people-to-people and cultural ties adds to the complexity that policy has to address on a sustained basis. How well India leverages its geography is a considerable part of its relevance to the world. To the extent that it is able to influence the Indian Ocean and participate in the Indo-Pacific, its global stock will rise commensurately. And if its prosperity and progress serve as a lifting tide for the larger subcontinent, then this would be even more consequential.

History may be a mixed blessing for most states, but making the best of it is nevertheless still a policy compulsion. In India's case, Partition not only reduced its stature but also cut it off from proximate regions where it had long enjoyed respect and influence. In recent years, reclaiming its strategic legacy has been a major endeavour. The graduation from Look East into an Act East policy highlighted the seriousness of connectivity and security interests in Southeast Asia. It was also the first step towards defining an extended neighbourhood.